

Pre-Release Copyright & PRO Checklist

For Jeffrey River — Acoustic Folk Singer-Songwriter | Sandpoint, ID

Step 1 — Prepare Your Works (Before Filing)

- Finalize demo recordings (MP3 or WAV) for each song you want protected.
- Type up clean lyric sheets for each song (PDF or Word).
- Save a master folder: one subfolder per song with audio + lyrics + writing notes.
- Confirm you are the sole author — or list all co-writers & their splits.

Step 2 — Register Copyright (U.S. Copyright Office)

- Go to **copyright.gov** → click "Register a Copyright" → eCO login.
- Create an account (free).
- Choose application type: **Group of Unpublished Works** (GRUW) — up to 10 songs, one fee.
- Select work type: **Sound Recording + Musical Work** (covers both composition and recording if you own both).
- Pay fee: **\$85** (group) or **\$45** (single work).
- Upload audio files + lyric sheets for each song.
- Submit and save confirmation email + case number.

Protection is effective from the filing date, even though certificate takes a few months.

Step 3 — Register with a PRO (Performance Royalties)

- Pick one: **ASCAP** (\$50 one-time) or **BMI** (free).
- Register as both a **Writer** and a **Publisher** (you keep 100% if self-published).
- Add each song to your PRO catalog (title, co-writers, splits).
- This collects royalties when your songs are played on radio, live venues, streaming, TV, etc.

Step 4 — Before You Distribute (Spotify/Apple/YouTube)

- Pick a distributor: **DistroKid** (~\$23/yr unlimited) or **TuneCore**.
- Set release date at least **3–4 weeks out** for Spotify editorial playlist pitching.
- Register song with **The MLC** (free) — collects mechanical royalties from streaming.
- Add **ISRC code** (distributor provides) and **ISWC code** (PRO provides).
- Claim your **Spotify for Artists** and **Apple Music for Artists** profiles.

Step 5 — Ongoing Protection Habits

- Date-stamp every new demo (email it to yourself or save to cloud with timestamp).
- File a new GRUW group registration every 6–12 months for new unreleased songs.
- Keep a running songwriter log: title, date written, co-writers, splits.
- Before any co-write session, agree on splits in writing (simple email is fine).

Quick Cost Summary: Copyright group \$85 • PRO \$0–\$50 • MLC free • Distributor ~\$23/yr

Bottom line: File the group copyright *before* your single goes public. Everything else can happen in parallel.